

# PEAK ↑ HUMAN



What We  
Can Learn  
from the  
Rise and Fall of  
Golden Ages



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## CONCLUSION:

# FURTHER RISE OR INEVITABLE DECLINE?

*Scipio, when he looked upon [Carthage] as it was utterly perishing and in the last throes of its complete destruction, is said to have shed tears and wept openly for his enemies... realizing that all cities, nations, and authorities must, like men, meet their doom.*

APPIAN OF ALEXANDRIA<sup>1</sup>

**M**y daughter recently told me: ‘Every time I study history, my reaction is, *wow*, I wouldn’t want to live there.’ She’s right, of course. Prosperity, peace and progress are rare in human history. It has only been a normal state of affairs in some regions, in some eras, and every time it was eventually snuffed out. Don’t take it for granted. If we want our culture to thrive, it is necessary to think about what makes that possible and what ruins it.

Ages become golden because they imitate and innovate. They first emerge because of cheating. They didn’t come up with all the innovations that made them prosper; instead they borrowed or stole them from others.

Openness to the rest of the world gave these cultures access to the power of other people’s brains, habits and skills, and so broadened their ideas of what is possible. They all chose different strategies to achieve this. Athenian, Italian and Dutch merchants picked up new ideas on their business trips. Rome absorbed more methods and peoples by conquest than foreign trade, and the Abbasids actively sponsored a translation project to lay their hands on the world’s knowledge.

But they were all heavily reliant on trade, migration and intellectual exchange. International trade, especially, tends to expose cultures to new ways of doing things and breaks down the perception that only one way is possible, even in non-economic areas like politics, art and religion. This explains why so many of these cultures are maritime. They are always going further and seeing more.

The Athenians and the Dutch embraced foreign trade out of weakness. They just couldn’t grow enough food, and were delighted to find out that exchange gave them not only all the food they needed but superior wealth besides. The Roman and the Abbasid empires embraced trade out of strength; they had built vast free-trade zones where production and innovations from anywhere rapidly spread all over it. Medieval European cities were reborn through their trade links, and the Anglosphere finally made the world safe for global trade. It was a difficult task to stop local magnates and pirates from disrupting trade, but it paid off spectacularly in each case.

But there is a limit to how far imitation can get you. To make this progress self-propelling and really usher in a golden age, these cultures had to combine these new ideas and inputs with their own thoughts and methods to create innovations, from higher agricultural yields to artistic rebellions. This takes inclusivity back home. People have to be allowed and encouraged to test their own ways of doing things, even when the elite or the majority finds it uncomfortable. You also need lots of people. All of these cultures were highly urbanized.

One prerequisite for inclusivity is the rule of law, so that people are not governed by the whims of individual rulers, but by predictable rules, applied equally to the whole population. No civilization did this perfectly. They all practised slavery and they did not treat women as citizens with equal rights, but, compared with other cultures, earlier and contemporary, they were much more inclusive, and that made a difference.

Athens had its direct democracy, which gave every free man a voice in the rule, and the Anglosphere pioneered a liberal democracy with division of powers. The Roman Republic, the Italian city-states and the Dutch Republic were controlled by the wealthy, but power was dispersed and, compared with contemporaries, their checks and balances played an important role in reining in arbitrary government power. The rulers of the Roman Empire, the Abbasid Caliphate and Song China held the power over every individual's life and death, but even they had a system of laws to adhere to. However, this centralization meant that their systems were more fragile. An enlightened despot could at any time be replaced by an unenlightened one. Some form of division of power has been instrumental in the protection of freedom, as the American founders learned from ancient civilizations.

The other requisites for inclusivity are free markets and free minds. To bring something new into the world, people must be allowed to experiment with and exchange new theories, arguments, goods and services. Every major technological innovation is 'an act of rebellion against conventional wisdom and vested interests', explains the economic historian Joel Mokyr, and if conventional wisdom and vested interest are in positions to command what can and can't be pursued, the result is stagnation.<sup>2</sup>

One reason why these societies were so successful was that an openness for surprises from a larger group of people allowed them to make use of the local knowledge and creativity that is dispersed throughout every society and can never be centralized to a royal palace, a feudal lord or a guild.

The golden eras in this book were unlike one another in this regard, but they all provided a much higher degree of economic freedom and intellectual freedom than other contemporary civilizations. They gave farmers, manufacturers and merchants more space to test new methods and technologies, and philosophers, scientists and artists more freedom to explore knowledge and visions. They simply put more ideas and business models on the table, and therefore had a greater chance to find successful ones.

This progress became self-sustaining because, at a certain point, it started transforming the self-identity of these civilizations. When more people started realizing what could be done, it encouraged a broader culture of optimism, energy and vigour. Many seem to have taken a great pride in being there, at that particular moment, no doubt partly the result of clever use of elite propaganda in creating a narrative of status and accomplishment, but mostly because of proof of concept.

So even poor Athenians understood that they could stand up and argue in the Assembly, just like the mighty. Chinese farmers observed that they didn't have to farm like their ancestors had done. Italian artists realized that they could also test novel materials and motifs. British instrument-makers were inspired by famous innovations to tweak and tinker in their own workshops. It's as if, at some point, a dynamic culture provides people with permission and stimulus to rebel, in Mokyr's sense. And that creates a tremendous expansion of creative energy.

However, eventually, the Great Status Quo Filter came for all these golden ages. Often the road to decline was paved with war, pandemics and climate-induced famines, but these are constants in human history, and cultures have also often bounced back from such episodes. Yet, in some instances, these crises gave the conventional wisdom and vested interest that Mokyr talked about a chance to fight back and upend the openness to surprises that signified these societies. A crisis often created an urge to retreat to something familiar, like some imagined good old days, fixed economic relations or an unvarnished faith.

All these golden ages experienced a death-to-Socrates moment, when they soured on their previous commitment to open intellectual exchange and abandoned curiosity for control. In the crisis-torn late Roman Empire, pagans started persecuting Christians, and Christians pagans. When Song China faced invasions, it turned Confucianism into state ideology. When the Abbasid Empire started fragmenting, the caliphs built an oppressive alliance between state and Church. The Renaissance ended when

embattled Protestants and Counter-Reformation Catholics built their respective state–Church alliances to persecute dissenters and scientists. Even the tolerant Dutch Republic was taken over by Calvinist zealots in the face of destructive invasions and economic downturns.

The new orthodoxies were often upheld by rulers who started centralizing societies and undermining the rule of law. The late Roman emperors became increasingly imposing and authoritarian, the Seljuk strongmen built a system for control of markets and minds, Chinese emperors after the Song dynasty took it upon themselves to regulate everything from farming to hairstyles, and late Renaissance rulers with cannons and gunpowder razed city walls and republican institutions. And even in the liberal Dutch Republic, the prince of Orange dismantled checks and balances and turned himself into a de-facto king. Hard times create strongmen, and strongmen create even harder times.

As free speech was replaced by orthodoxies, free markets were often replaced with increased economic controls towards the end of these periods. When at times states found it difficult to raise taxes, they undermined property rights and voluntary exchange to take as much as they could, just as when Romans, Abbasids and Chinese tried to fix social relations by feudalizing the economy. A recurrent sign of decline was that they raised money by creating more of it. They debased the coinage, unleashing inflation and chaos in the economy.

Disastrously, they also started abandoning the international trade that had provided them with both wealth and creativity. Sometimes trade broke down because war and fragmentation made roads and sea-lanes unsafe, as in Rome and the late Renaissance. Ming China simply banned foreign trade because it upset the status quo. Abbasid militarization of the economy undermined the previously central role of merchants. After having faced tariffs from other countries, the Dutch eventually implemented their own.

Just as openness had made these cultures strong, orthodoxies and oppression made them weak. When just one answer came to be acceptable in politics, religion and economics, experiment and innovation ground to a halt, and mankind returned to its more natural state: stagnation and hunger.

It is heartbreaking to read the accounts of travellers who made it to Rome, Baghdad, Chinese port towns or Dutch cities just a few years too late. These places had just recently been considered the wonders of mankind but were now found to be depopulated and impoverished. The scanty remains of bygone better times.

The pressing question is of course where this leaves us. The golden age that we are in right now is the most extraordinary ever, because a revolution in communication, transportation and trade under the protection of an Anglosphere world order has broken down geographical barriers to the adoption of local breakthroughs. In Roman and Abbasid times, the scientific, technological and cultural innovations of one region could rapidly be adopted in the rest of the empire. Now, for the first time, they can quickly be adopted all around the world. As a result, for the first time in history we do not just have progress constrained to one region and one civilization. The whole of mankind has been touched by it.

Consequently, the early scientific and industrial achievements of Great Britain and the United States, which once seemed so unique, have been repeated in all corners of the world. Since 1820, the share of people in extreme poverty globally has been reduced from roughly 8 out of 10 to fewer than 1 out of 10. Life expectancy has shot up from thirty to seventy-four. Child mortality has declined from almost 50 per cent to less than 4 per cent.

The same era has witnessed some of the greatest libertarian accomplishments, intimately associated with this progress. In most countries, religion has gone from being something imposed by force to a private matter. Legal slavery has been abolished all over the world. Increasingly, women have been set

free from laws that treated them as the property of fathers and husbands. Though piecemeal and imperfect, this is quite possibly the greatest advance ever, setting half of mankind free in the blink of an eye, in historical terms. It's as golden as it gets.

But nothing lasts forever. We have had a run of roughly 200 years. Few golden ages last longer than that. What does history tell us about our chances?

Regrettably, many ominous signs of decline are clearly present in our time. Like Athens, the United States experienced its own moment of hubristic overreach in the early twenty-first century, believing it could reshape the entire Middle East with the Afghanistan and Iraq war, squandering lives and resources while alienating world opinion. The financial crash of 2008 at least temporarily deprived America of its role as inspiration to the world, when countries like China decided that they should stop trying to emulate it. Like other major powers, the US has solved present funding problems by burdening future generations with a crippling public debt, which historically has had a tendency to usher in destructive inflation or panic in the markets.

In a pattern that is familiar from the end of many golden ages, a series of crises, such as financial crashes, migration flows, the pandemic and geopolitical tensions, has replaced the confident, exploratory mindset with a sense that the world is dangerous and that we need to protect ourselves from it. In just a few years, we seem to have gone from what Thucydides described as the Athenian mindset of being open to acquire something new to the Spartan mentality of shutting the world out to preserve what one already has.

Like many old and tired societies, we have a tendency to try to fossilize what we have, and a growing number of regulations and standards make it more difficult for rapid adaptation and disruptive innovation. It is increasingly difficult in rich countries to build anything anywhere or for upstarts to repeat what major incumbents once did. As the journalist Alan Beattie has observed, EU officials often seem like the dinosaurs in Jurassic Park that hunt by movement: 'If part of the economy is growing fast, they're rapidly on its tail.'<sup>3</sup>

Most worryingly, rich countries have experienced a major backlash against globalization and trade, and immigrants have become scapegoats, just as they were in so many other eras of decline, potentially shutting us out from our most potent source of constant revitalization. All around the world there has been a resurgence of ideas of nationalism, repatriation and centralized industrial policy. After the global financial crisis of 2008, international trade has stopped growing, and indicators of progress have slowed down.

Simultaneously, two different reactions against the sprawling diversity of modern society have emerged, which are mirror images of each other: a hard, nationalist right and a radical, illiberal left. They are both obsessed with identity politics and pursue a dream of sameness, where alternative ideas and cultures are cancelled or deported out of their pure, homogenous utopia. As a consequence, some of them storm the stage when they lose a campus debate, and others storm the US Capitol when they lose an election. Their ambition to enforce one idea on everyone is portrayed as a quest for unity, but since it establishes a zero-sum game, it only fuels tensions and conflict.

These factions are not yet in a position to impose stifling orthodoxies on entire societies, but in countries where either of these tribes get lasting power, rule of law usually suffers. Some seem to be longing for a Caesar. Democracies like Turkey, Hungary and Mexico show how quickly an illiberal leader can dismantle checks and balances and centralize societies. There is no lack of cautionary tales even in old democracies.

Another worrying parallel with history is that the rivals of open societies have caught up with many of its achievements. Just like Germanic tribes learned organizational skills and weapons technology from the Romans, and Mongols took from the Chinese the gunpowder and steel that would destroy



them, terrorist organizations and China and Russia constantly imitate the methods and technologies of the free world, and so become a greater threat to it than they would otherwise be.

Both China and Russia have recently taken a totalitarian turn and are working hard to devastate neighbours like Hong Kong and Ukraine, partly because they realize that their own models might not stand up to an example of a prosperous, open society on their borders. In cooperation with rogue states like Iran and North Korea, they are threatening whole regions. They are also trying to undermine democracies in Europe and the US, by stoking our divisions via propaganda and social media. As the journalist and historian Anne Appelbaum has warned, these authoritarians have learned to collaborate across traditional ideological divides. They exchange tactics for stealing, repressing and staying in power, while trading the technologies needed to achieve their aims.

Will they succeed? It won't be easy. The military historian Bret Devereaux argues that the Anglosphere moment and the progress it made possible have fundamentally transformed international relations.<sup>4</sup> The traditional conflict pattern in a state system is that countries tend to align against the one that appears strongest for the moment (today, the US), to contain its advance. If this power manages to break out in any case and become the hegemon, these countries have an interest to align with it to survive as a client state, but if the hegemon stumbles, their interest shifts back to balancing and turning on the hegemon all at once, leading to rapid disintegration.

This pattern has suddenly changed. Of the world's thirty largest economies, almost all are allies of the United States, twenty of them formal treaty allies. Just two of the thirty biggest, Russia and China, try to challenge the Anglosphere-led world order, but they have a hard time finding reliable friends among advanced states. The more they show their revisionist ambitions, and the more they remind others what a world without US leadership would look like, the less others are interested in going along. Instead these countries then lean even more towards America, and seem to be more eager to help countries exposed to Russian or Chinese aggression and trade coercion.

The reason is not that America is such a bully that others feel they have to cosy up to it or else. They do it because it's not. (When at times it is, the interest in alternatives grows.) It is instead seen as the most powerful guarantor of an open world order that they have a common interest in. They would do what they can to uphold it even if America itself disappeared, physically or spiritually.

This is not a Roman empire that countries are forced into, or a Delian League that they cannot leave. It is an informal grouping of countries that have realized that they have a common interest in peace and trade. In fact, many of them are freeriding on the security guarantees supplied by the United States, rather than the other way around.

But even though they should of course pay for their own defence, America also has an interest in such a broad alliance of free countries. It has created an unusual situation where everybody else does not gang up on the dominant power and look for any chance to trip it up. Without the coalition, it is likely that growing regional hegemonies would at some point use their power to push America out and sever its trade routes, for example. Historically, the hegemon had to give in to such behaviour or go to war. If it happened today, the US has a network of allies that would punish the perpetrator politically, diplomatically and financially, making it much less likely.

As long as the richest countries, with some 60 per cent of GDP and overwhelming financial and technological muscle, stay united, it is incredibly difficult to upend this international order. It does not mean that it is impossible. Pericles and Johan de Witt found out to their detriment that everyone is not always willing to act according to their own best interest when they are distracted by pride, religion or ideology. Miscalculations or machismo could very well throw the world into tumult. A major war, possibly involving weapons of mass destruction, could upend the world order.

But the biggest threat to an open world does not come from strong opponents, but from weak

proponents. Growing fear and nationalism in major democracies could easily lead them to overlook their interest in openness, or lose the stamina to fight for it. There is, for example, nothing inevitable about America consistently taking on the role of defender of peaceful cooperation and open trade. Unfortunately, there is not even a guarantee that liberal democracies will remain liberal democracies. Let's not forget that we usually find our worst enemy in the mirror. As the historian D. C. Sumervell once remarked, societies don't die from natural causes, but from suicide or murder – and it is nearly always the former.

At this point in most books on the long lines of history, the author tells us to prepare to invest in the biggest challenges for the future, whether it be future geopolitical challenges, existential risks of technology, the environment or demographic changes. I won't, because I don't believe as much in dealing with potential weaknesses as I do in building on our strengths.

The reason is that the nature of our problems will have changed completely in a hundred years' time and our arsenal of possible solutions will, if we do things right, have been radically expanded. Some of the worst challenges will come as total surprises, and therefore the solutions will also have to surprise us. While it certainly doesn't hurt to think about which ones they might be, our most important preparation is to have a dynamic culture that helps us to acquire more prosperity, knowledge and technological capacity overall. That will help us to be resilient, no matter what form future problems take.

If we worry about where we will be in a century's time instead of solving problems here and now, it is not very constructive. We might not even make it to those challenges in that case. After all, we are always wrong about the future. Bear in mind that the whole world considered overpopulation a horrible threat to human survival right up until the very moment it started thinking that underpopulation was the real menace. So the solution is never a single Big Solution, but an open culture that allows us to continually adapt and innovate around every challenge the world throws our way.

How do we do this? How do we stay open when the world seems threatening? We do it by learning from history. It tells us that we have a tendency to react quickly and counterproductively to threats, rather than opening up to the broad diversity of millions and millions of answers, and the trial and error that will allow for better solutions to appear. The real solution is not in one idea, but in ten thousand things, as the medieval Chinese knew so well.

Elites who want to protect their status and status quo by rejecting surprises have to learn that this would just allow them to rule over decaying societies. And all of us have to realize that what we now cherish is the result of such processes of experiment and innovation. Everything a reactionary is now trying to preserve from change is something that a previous reactionary failed to stop.

Jason Feifer has the perfect question to help us understand this: 'What did we once fear, that we now love?' The question is so important because almost every innovation, from the novel to the internet, from democracy to the Eiffel Tower, was once seen as bizarre and threatening; at first we could only see what we might lose and not what we could gain. But then we got used to it, started to use it and learned to love it. You probably have many examples of this in your own life; I know I have.

Only by staying open to such surprises, and learning how to benefit from them, can we continue to make progress as individuals and as societies. By understanding that we often learn to love what we once rejected instinctively, we can build a tolerance for unpredictability. Or someone else will.

One difference with previous golden ages is that we now have more eggs in different baskets. Once upon a time, if Athens or Baghdad failed, it was game over. Now we have 200 different states around the world, and roughly fifty of them are prosperous, open societies. They are deeply embedded in

networks of communication and trade. A majority of the world's population has access to the accumulated knowledge of mankind. Some of these countries will no doubt make terrible mistakes, falter and fail, but that won't stop others from picking up the torch.

This prompts the question of where the next golden age will come from. A decade ago, many would have said China but, since then, its leaders have re-centralized both the economy and culture, and stifled the creativity and innovation that could have made it prosper. It seems to have got stuck in the Status Quo Filter even before it experienced a golden age, and this shows that progress is never guaranteed, but dependent on particular courses of action.

Great but subdued cultures like Turkey and Iran have the potential of making the opposite journey, if they manage to rid themselves of present political strangleholds. It is easy to see how some other dynamic countries, like Poland, Vietnam and India, have a chance of reaching stages of self-sustaining renewal, and that Africa, with its large, young population and massive resources, should be able to provide us with many thriving examples. We learn from history that it can happen suddenly, even in unexpected places.

But perhaps this is the wrong way of looking at it. What's new in the present era of globalization and digital communication is that we have a truly global civilization – not in terms of values and policies, but in knowledge and skills. This in itself is one of the great achievements of this golden age. Every literate person anywhere in the world now has the chance to access the accumulated knowledge of humanity and to learn skills in any field. We can each decide whether we want to harness this remarkable technological power to enhance our ability to flourish or to bicker with strangers online.

This means that no one country will hold a monopoly on the ideas that will make them prosper. Future golden ages will be more diluted, since everyone else can emulate them instantly. It also means that the divides will increasingly be seen within every society, between cities, regions, businesses and individuals – between those who embrace transformation to grow and adapt and those who cling to the comfort of stagnation; between those who stay open to acquiring something new, and those who seek to shut the world out to protect what they already have.

Every civilization has a bit of the Athenian and of the Spartan within it. So do you and I. We decide who we let out.